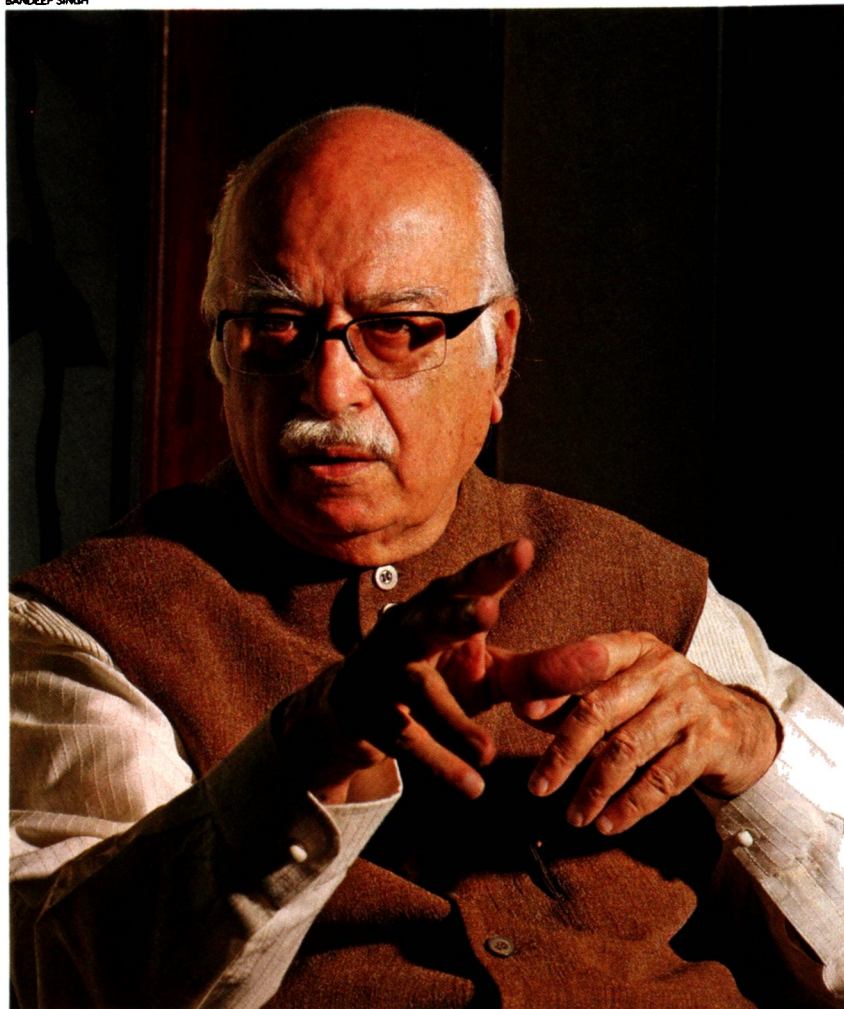


THE BJP'S 81-YEAR-OLD PRIME MINISTERIAL CANDIDATE IS READY TO TAKE ON EITHER MANMOHAN SINGH OR RAHUL GANDHI

BANDEEP SINGH



THE BJP WON'T POLITICISE THE PRIME MINISTER'S SURGERY BUT IS WATCHING THE ENEMY CAMP WITH MUCH GLEE.

next polls, did a rethink. Earlier too when loyal Congressmen had floated Rahul's name for prime minister, Pawar had pointed out that they already had a candidate in Manmohan. Apart from Lalu Yadav, the other allies will need more than the Gandhi name to support the 38-year-old Rahul as prime minister. And the main Opposition, whose prime ministerial

candidate is 81 years old, won't openly politicise the prime minister's surgery. But BJP is watching with understandable glee the leadership confusion within the Congress. The party thinks the Congress will be foolish if it projects an inexperienced Rahul Gandhi as the next prime minister. "They will give us our biggest issue on a platter. If they do that, we will just tear him apart," said

a BJP leader. "If they project Manmohan Singh and the development under him, we will counter it with the comparison in each key area during the NDA regime," he added.

The BJP has already started working on this. The party has come out with a comparison between the NDA and UPA governments on the development of National Highways. "We will call the UPA's bluff and go ahead with these comparisons in other fields irrespective of Congress's leadership," said another BJP leader.

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The prime minister, always a gentleman and lately a politician in the making, is not used to flexing muscles. He is the thinking ruler, the guru of the marketplace. And it is the economy, his primary area of expertise, that is going to test his leadership. Hopefully, the test won't be as severe as the one that undid the last American president, who was Manmohan's partner in the historic nuclear deal. As the world shudders at the prospect of an economic apocalypse, no government can afford a leader without an action plan. Manmohan needs to unveil one the moment he comes out of the hospital. For, India too is experiencing the pain of the worst economic crisis: jobs are vanishing and farmers are committing suicide. And it's all happening on the eve of the general elections. Then there is the assertion of the regional parties, who need to be kept in good humour. The man of high principles has already made a lot of concessions for the sake of survival. And the satraps who supply oxygen to the coalition are likely to be more aggressive in their bargain before and after the elections. As Sonia Gandhi continues to be the supreme leader who is not yet accessible and acceptable as the master of realpolitik, can Manmohan, himself an accidental politician, deal with the vulpine cohabitants of the UPA? Well Doctor, to withstand the vicissitudes of power in the world's most volatile democracy, you need a mighty heart.

with Bhavna Vij Aurora